



Matchday stillness: Maitland Place wears a quiet, almost genteel calm outside the Sinhalese Sports Club, broad roads and old trees masking the fact that international cricket stirs just around the corner. SAHIL MATHUR

COLOMBO BETWEEN THE CREASE

Colombo 7 is among the city's poshest pockets. The roads are broad, the footpaths wide enough for three people to walk abreast without stepping off the pavement. Old trees line one side, and colonial-era buildings sit quietly in the background. Maitland Place almost conceals the fact that international cricket unfolds behind its walls.

The Sinhalese Sports Club (SSC), home of Sri Lanka Cricket, dates back to the late 19th century and carries much of Colombo's sporting prestige.

Ironically, for all the space outside, the ground itself is compact. A mix of concrete stands and grass embankments brings the capacity to around 15,000. The press box mirrors that intimacy: nearly 50 of us negotiate elbow room and charging points. It gets tighter down the metal staircase leading to the press conference room, one person per step, laptops tucked under arms. The room can barely accommodate 25. Two studio lights glare as cricketers answer questions from passionate Pakistani journalists.

Yet the setting has its charm. Pakistan's game against the USA, the first night match at the SSC, glowed differently against the trees of Cinnamon Gardens. Among local reporters, it sparked hope of a future

pink-ball Test.

Less than six kilometres away stands the R. Premadasa Stadium. Turn onto Khetarama Temple Road and the surroundings shift. The Sebastian Canal runs nearby, and tuk-tuks are repaired in narrow lanes. Built nearly a century after the SSC, Khetarama rises from humbler surroundings.

Inside, the roles reverse. There is space for wider staircases and more generous seating. Yet the media turnout for Australia's opener against Ireland was barely half of what had assembled at the SSC days earlier.

Four days in Colombo meant navigating between two historic venues, just 5.5 kilometres apart, in neighbourhoods that could hardly be more contrasting. Different postcodes. Different energies. And a cricketing carnival in between.

Sahil Mathur

WARM SHORES, COLD GESTURES

Sri Lanka, originally known as Serendip, the inspiration behind the word serendipity, and also referred to as Ilangai and Ceylon, is a nation high on warmth and beauty. Colombo, the capital, with its high-rises and quaint homes with mango trees in their backyards, presents a picture of urban rush and pastoral delight.

The cricketing fraternity is present in full strength for the ICC T20 World Cup match featuring India and Pakistan on February 15. The match belies the hype and becomes a one-sided outing for Suryakumar Yadav's men to savour. A taste, which they turned bitter by refusing to shake hands with the Pakistanis.

A lightning trip concludes with the return flight to Chennai. A group of Sinhalese men and women are excited as they embark on a Buddhist circuit tour of India. There are many threads that tie the Indian subcontinent together even if politicians may have their own axe to grind.

K.C. Vijaya Kumar

THE GREAT ORANGE PLOT TWIST

The world's largest sports stadium has its pitfalls. Filling up the 132,000-capacity Narendra Modi Stadium in Ahmedabad is no mean task, and even a decent crowd is sometimes outnumbered by the empty bright orange seats, lending the venue a barren look.

Therefore, the announcement in the press box that the group-stage match between South Africa and New Zealand had registered the highest turnout of the T20 World Cup up until that point came as a bit of a surprise. With tickets starting at a mere Rs. 100 for the tournament's first battle of equals, the official attendance stood at an impressive 54,923.

"It's a bit unexpected to get such a big crowd. But as players, you want to play in front of a vibey atmosphere, a loud crowd, and that's exactly what tonight was, so great to have a really big turnout," South African skipper Aiden Markram said after his team's rout of the Kiwis. India wasn't playing, nor was it a tournament final, but the fans turned up to support their 'second-favourite' team. "We feel like we're their second-favourite team, apart from India. So, it's always nice travelling around the country and seeing people's smiles on their faces and how much they love cricket," New Zealand batter Daryl Mitchell remarked.

The next game at the venue was India's face-off against the Netherlands. One couldn't help but smirk at the idea that if the crowd didn't show up in numbers for the dead-rubber, the empty bright orange seats would suggest the Dutch had more support than the host. The 69,000 fans, however, averted such a possibility. Nevertheless, it was a memorable experience for the Dutch. "It's probably a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity to play for so many people. I hope everyone soaked it all in," Netherlands all-rounder Bas de Leede gushed.

Dhruva Prasad